

Resurrecting Civility

Processing Information Socially at the
Sunset of Empire and the Dawn of AI
(a taste of an introduction)

I. An invitation to build a new science and a new humanity

Greetings, friends. In the pages that follow, I will lay out a vision and plan to establish a new science, a new way for human beings to understand one another and our public life, our place in the world. You might think such a plan overly ambitious, and indeed you may be underestimating[the charge. The plan I will outline is for the creation of a new master science, yet a science as fully as physics, chemistry, biology, and neuroscience are sciences. A successful master science in this sense will aim to provide a coherent and integrative account of everything that is true, and to provide the best case so far for accepting that account. That's a high bar already. But the goal of this master science is higher, still: it will seek out, foster, and coordinate multiple accounts of everything, and measure the progress of any emerging candidates in their interactions with their rivals. That might seem like a task better suited for a university, or a whole network of universities, and indeed it is. But it is not a task which universities are currently inclined or organized to undertake. So we begin here, sketching a comparatively modest vision and plan to transform all of social life, including universities, that the needed master science might unfold.

Already we can see that this new science must begin with two fairly different sorts of concerns. One of these is the assembly of thought and practice across disciplines and lived experience into even just one integrated, stable, and promising whole. The second involves repeating this process in multiple instances and comparing the results: identification, encouragement to maturity and eventual placement of a number of such putatively coherent accounts into circumstances supporting interactions that can be quantitatively investigated, and from which the data for this new science can be obtained. Thus our task is something like building a team, so that we can build a league, so that we can advance a craft of playing well. No such league emerges *de novo*; it must take elements already assembled for some other purpose and encourage them into service for another, namely, to play under the rules of a new and transformed game, ordered under the rules of a league. And so our task here, on this analogy, is to sketch the rules that would govern play in such a league, assemble a single team to play in it, and nearly simultaneously recruit other teams to play against the first. The rule-governed activity in question is the building of an ordered account of the whole universe in all its dimensions, facets and possibilities. And not just a single account: lots of them. Not as many as we possibly can, but as many as anyone can make a plausible case that we actually should: as many as will advance the end of arriving at the best account, so far, in theory and in practice, of the world and our place in it.

So we are going to define a game, design a league for it, and then put a team together to get the competition started. If this sounds to you more like a practical, rather than an academic and theoretical activity, you've been paying attention. While it might be a game that universities can play, it is radically different from the game that universities

currently play, though it would include much of what they currently do: on this, much more later. But that this is a practical and not a merely academic activity is an important point to note from the start. Even the writing and reading of this very text are not primarily theoretical activities: they are a recruitment exercise, a sales pitch, a blessing, an interaction, an invitation to join a team. This is not an academic paper primarily attempting to persuade a readership to think differently. Kindly receive it as more of an invitation to transform what you are currently doing, and to try to build something very much more than--and with--what you are currently building.

Want to play? The game/team/league analogy for this project is apt, but less so for some purposes than others. This project aims to construct a new science, even a new world. There is both a seriousness and a product inherent in that construction image that isn't quite captured as a game. So let's add a second analogy. We are going to build an infrastructure for a new town, and then erect a model building on it. Every new building will tap into that infrastructure (well or poorly), but not every new building will be the first new home. In fact, the success of the city will thrive on the development of multiple buildings, requiring and promoting selection procedures both for buildings compatible with and fulfilling the purpose of that infrastructure, as well as requirements governing competition for occupants/residents of those buildings and thus of that town. On this analogy, the purpose of living together in this town is to figure out how to live together well, and (unlike most towns) each building is a whole experiment in community, in some sense conversing and perhaps contesting with communities in each neighboring building. OK, then; let's build something together.

This invitation is extended to a very wide variety of persons, suitable for filling a wide range of restructured roles whose precise tasks will become clearer as the project unfolds. Before starting down that road, though, it may be useful to sketch three primary classes of concerns, one or more of which anyone disposed to entertain this invitation is likely to share.

Consider first a cluster of concerns drawn from reflection on many of the problems facing us in our present time. We find ourselves in the middle of an information food fight. We have greater access to far more information about the world than ever before, and this rate of increase seems to be accelerating. One might have thought that such an abundance of access ought to have had a positive impact on our choices--in some ways it surely has--yet the volume and the variety of input seems too much to process. We band together to accomplish this ever-more difficult information-processing task, but our groupings seem perhaps accidental and in any case not fully justified. Yet even while we acknowledge this theoretically, many of us find ourselves or others in groups who are increasingly certain they are right. We cluster in interpretive tribes, engaged in much more talk than action: frustration turns out to have limited adhesive properties. But we hold on as best we can to our raft of right-mindedness, leaving behind others whose misguided values come from having associated with the wrong kind of people, their pool of evidence fed by a steady flow of fake news from the wrong sources. All the while we are hard pressed to explain how our brothers and sisters--perhaps we grew up together--became worse, and came to know so much less than we. In this melee, we face immediate existential challenges--if only we could agree on what they were--without on anyone's account the social or intellectual capital we need to overcome them.

To those with concerns in this first cluster, participation in this project will provide clarity about how we arrived at this state. We will explore a new paradigm—just wait until you see it for yourself—for leveraging the riches of our information age in vastly more promising ways. Making a virtue of necessity, we will usefully redeploy the power of diversity from its current role of promoting heat rather than light in discussion, and chilling polarization in social relations. Instead, we will harness diversity by strengthening rival perspectives for civil interaction with one another, sharpening their resources for recruitment, training and persuasion in the context of a healthy league. In the resulting contests, performance (under a theory soon to be articulated) can be predicted, measured and managed with data from productive interactions, providing both explanations and remedies for the fruitless interactivity of our present day.

For many, the challenges we face today and our seeming resourcelessness in responding to them are already reasonably well explained; the biggest challenge keeping us from solving the problems of the present is our failure to preserve or recover something from the past. For what is required to make progress today has slipped away in some forgotten age, whether long or more recently passed. People back then knew how to live, and we now lack something vital which they more nearly had than we. Their perspectives and values were time-honored, even perennial and wise. We've lost things of incalculable value on the road from then to now, and for whatever reasons—failure to notice the loss, softening of our moral fiber, a fall from grace—we now live in a much poorer culture with no clear path to recovery. To those who mourn the passing of some such days and ways, this present project offers a path toward better understanding what has been lost and where it came from in the first place, including criteria for discerning

loss from gain. Armed with craft and criteria, we will find tools to better recognize, recover in some measure, and rebuild in others, cultural treasures no longer lost, to be added to new treasures yet unexplored, and employed to overcome our current challenges.

Finally, a spirit from the future adds its voice to a chorus begun by present and past. To overcome our current problems and recover from distant losses, we need to see clearly, but increasingly our eyes are blinded by visions of run-away advances in technology and science: in nanotechnology, neuroscience, genetics, computer science and intelligence. Over the horizon there be nanobots, CRISPR-edited genes, malevolent AI, autonomous weapon systems, and innumerable other threats, forecast to us season after season in Black Mirror episodes, daily on the nightly news and mind-numbingly-always in omnipresent Twitter streams. We are a hackable humanity at the dawn of AI. We don't know how to guide its development, and we don't know how much time we've got to figure it out. What we do know is that the power to process information is growing exponentially, a power controlled by an ever-narrowing subset in the domain of the intelligent, still largely human as far as we know, yet increasingly inscrutable in identity, purpose or algorithm. To those struggling to focus in the light of this new dawn, this project will provide useful filters and lenses: a model of intelligence, of disciplinary integration, and for tapping—both harnessing and liberating—the power of AI for promotion of civility and transformation into a new age that is both good and possible.

All of these voices, spectres from days now upon us, past and yet to come, point to the need for fundamental reform in how we understand and define ourselves, live together

in peace, and cooperate in building a rich future. This project will deliver a solution set that promises relief in the face of all these challenges. It will draw on long-neglected resources, resolve immediate challenges and point the way ahead, instilling well-grounded, actionable hope: a blueprint, supply list, budget and workplan for building a future together. Against such a bold promise, this effort might seem destined to fall short. How short is in part up to you.

As we proceed, we will need to identify, employ and advance a craft for construction: one we can use to lay an infrastructure, build on it, and maintain in good repair both the foundations and superstructure. Each building in our new town is a way of thinking and living together, at once both a lens and a community through which we see and act in the world. As a building becomes complete, so a lens becomes comprehensive, illuminating and guiding in an ever-larger space for living and learning. Just as buildings can be modularized and layered, so lenses can be additive and ordered, used in combination with one another to make a perspective more powerful, and what is seen, more precise. So the construction of theoretical and practical lenses—clusters of beliefs and commitments—is the craft we will use to build our city, a newly-ordered and better-informed humanity, clustered increasingly in stable and productively-interactive diversity. We will illustrate this craft, first, in the construction of our model home.

This craft of building will need a name. Without providing a long justification, let's just borrow one from Plato's *Republic*. Dialectic, defined here loosely as the craft of assembling propositions and commitments into consistent, fruitful and rhetorically attractive holistic perspectives, is the craft in question. It will turn out that this craft is

the construction, use and extension of practical models. This seems to be what contemporary neuroscience tells us corresponds with the more advanced functions of the human brain, and what the best current thought in computer science identifies as the goal of AI. So there is a case to be made for identifying this master craft with intelligence *simpliciter*, or with what Alasdair MacIntyre calls theoretical and practical rationality. But giving credit where it was first due, we'll call it dialectic.

So, let's build. Let's lay a foundation, a distilled set of claims and commitments that together constitute a model for understanding ourselves in our commonality and in our diversity. Let's build a new partnership among those sufficiently attracted to buy in. Let's write rules for a new game, a basis for fruitful interaction between those embracing that new model and alternatives to it. As we lay this new infrastructure, we will begin to identify and shape data for a new master science, and a foundation for a new civility. Because it is rooted, to some extent, in once well-established but now long-forgotten wisdom, our new master science will be in some sense recovered, and that new civility, resurrected. Because that rebirth must tear away from older ways of thinking to embrace and interweave new challenges and resources as fresh opportunities, what emerges from the cocoon will be in another sense a new creation, in some way definitive of a new species: *homo interconnectus*. (Catholic and other participants might recognize this new creation as Christ.)

II. Foundations of a new social infrastructure

This new model can be described in brief as a high-information-flow network of rich communities, to which we'll refer even more economically as a rich community network.

Its name plainly suggests some tasks required to construct the model: we will have to describe what communities we mean, and in what sense they are rich; information in what sense, the high flow of which, to what end. So we will shortly begin with communities, but even before that, with ourselves.